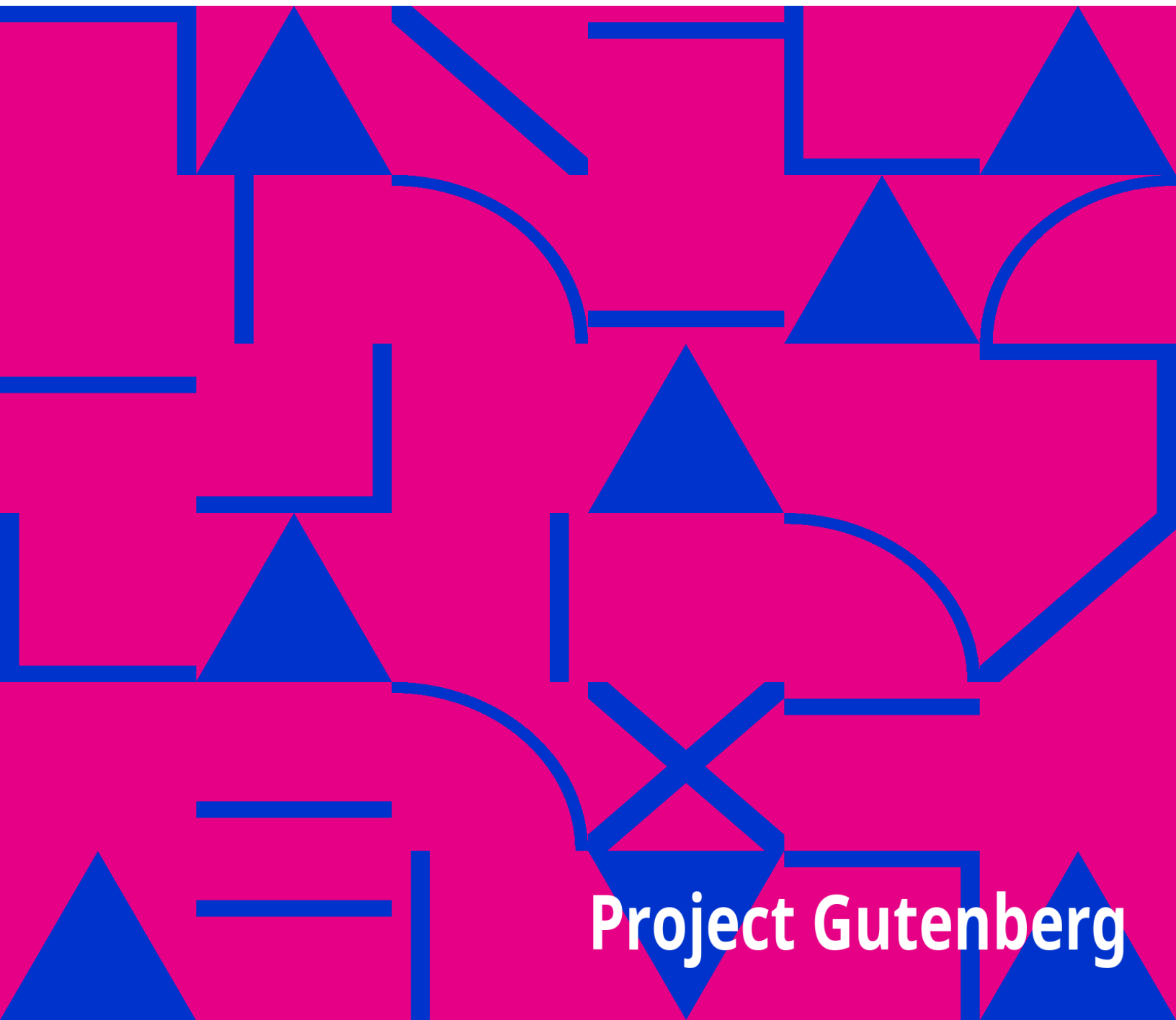


Pamela Giraud: A Play in Five Acts

Honoré de Balzac

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK
PAMELA GIRAUD: A PLAY IN FIVE ACTS ***

PAMELA GIRAUD

A PLAY IN FIVE ACTS

by Honore de Balzac

**Presented for the First Time at Paris at the
Theatre de la Gaite, September 26, 1843**

PERSONS OF THE
PLAY

PAMELA GIRAUD

ACT I

ACT II

ACT III

ACT IV

ACT V

PERSONS OF THE PLAY

General de Verby
Dupre, a lawyer
Rousseau, a wealthy merchant
Jules Rousseau, his son
Joseph Binet
Giraud, a porter
Chief of Special Police
Antoine, servant to the Rousseaus

Pamela Giraud
Madame du Brocard, a widow; aunt of Jules Rousseau
Madame Rousseau
Madame Giraud
Justine, chambermaid to Madame Rousseau

Sheriff
Magistrate
Police Officers
Gendarmes

SCENE: Paris

TIME: During the Napoleonic plots under Louis XVIII. (1815-1824)

PAMELA GIRAUD

ACT I

SCENE FIRST

(Setting is an attic and workshop of an artificial flower-maker. It is

poorly lighted by means of a candle placed on the work-table. The

ceiling slopes abruptly at the back allowing space to conceal a man.

On the right is a door, on the left a fireplace. Pamela is discovered

at work, and Joseph Binet is seated near her.)

Pamela, Joseph Binet and later Jules Rousseau.

Pamela

Monsieur Joseph Binet!

Joseph

Mademoiselle Pamela Giraud!

Pamela

I plainly see that you wish me to hate you.

Joseph

The idea! What? And this is the beginning of our love—Hate me!

Pamela

Oh, come! Let us talk sensibly.

Joseph

You do not wish, then, that I should express how much I love you?

Pamela

Ah! I may as well tell you plainly, since you compel me to do

so, that

I do not wish to become the wife of an upholsterer's apprentice.

Joseph

Is it necessary to become an emperor, or something like that, in order to marry a flower-maker?

Pamela

No. But it is necessary to be loved, and I don't love you in any way whatever.

Joseph

In any way! I thought there was only one way of loving.

Pamela

So there is, but there are many ways of not loving. You can be my friend, without my loving you.

Joseph

Oh!

Pamela

I can look upon you with indifference—

Joseph

Ah!

Pamela

You can be odious to me! And at this moment you weary me, which is worse!

Joseph

I weary her! I who would cut myself into fine pieces to do all that she wishes!

Pamela

If you would do what I wish, you would not remain here.

Joseph

And if I go away—Will you love me a little?

Pamela

Yes, for the only time I like you is when you are away!

Joseph

And if I never came back?

Pamela

I should be delighted.

Joseph

Zounds! Why should I, senior apprentice with M. Morel, instead of

aiming at setting up business for myself, fall in love with this young

lady? It is folly! It certainly hinders me in my career; and yet I

dream of her—I am infatuated with her. Suppose my uncle knew it!—But

she is not the only woman in Paris, and, after all, Mlle. Pamela

Giraud, who are you that you should be so high and mighty?

Pamela

I am the daughter of a poor ruined tailor, now become a porter. I gain

my own living—if working night and day can be called living—and it

is with difficulty that I snatch a little holiday to gather lilacs in

the Pres-Saint-Gervais; and I certainly recognize that the senior

apprentice of M. Morel is altogether too good for me. I do not wish to

enter a family which believes that it would thus form a mesalliance.

The Binets indeed!

Joseph

But what has happened to you in the last eight or ten days, my dear

little pet of a Pamela? Up to ten days ago I used to come and cut out

your flowers for you, I used to make the stalks for the

roses, and the

 hearts for the violets; we used to talk together, we sometimes used to

 go to the play, and have a good cry there—and I was "good Joseph,"

 "my little Joseph"—a Joseph in fact of the right stuff to make your

 husband. All of a sudden—Pshaw! I became of no account.

Pamela

 Now you must really go away. Here you are neither in the street, nor

 in your own house.

Joseph

 Very well, I'll be off, mademoiselle—yes, I'll go away! I'll have a

 talk in the porter's lodge with your mother; she does not ask anything

 better than my entrance into the family, not she; she won't change her

 mind!

Pamela

 All right! Instead of entering her family, enter her lodge, the

 porter's lodge, M. Joseph! Go and talk with my mother, go on! — (Exit

 Joseph.) Perhaps he'll keep their attention so that M. Adolph can get

 up stairs without being seen. Adolph Durand! What a pretty name! There

 is half a romance in it! And what a handsome young man! For the last

 fifteen days he has absolutely persecuted me. I knew that I was rather

 pretty; but I never believed I was all he called me. He must be an

 artist, or a government official! Whatever he is, I can't help liking

 him; he is so aristocratic! But what if his appearance were deceitful,

 and there were anything wrong about him!—For the letter which he has

 just sent me has an air of mystery about it— (She draws a

letter from

her bosom and reads it) "Expect me this evening. I wish to see you

alone, and, if possible, to enter unnoticed by any one; my life is in

danger, and oh! if you only knew what a terrible misfortune threatens

me! Adolph Durand." He writes in pencil. His life is in danger—Ah!

How anxious I feel!

Joseph (returning)

Just as I was going down stairs, I said to myself: "Why should Pamela"

(Jules' head appears at the window.)

Pamela

Ah!

Joseph

What's the matter?

(Jules disappears.)

Pamela

I thought I saw—I mean—I thought I heard a sound overhead. Just go

into the garret. Some one perhaps has hidden there. You are not

afraid, are you?

Joseph

No.

Pamela

Very well! Go up and search! Otherwise I shall be frightened for the

whole night.

Joseph

I will go at once. I will climb over the roof if you like.

(He passes through a narrow door that leads to the garret.)

Pamela (follows him)

Be quick! (Jules enters.) Ah! sir, what trouble you are giving me!

Jules

*It is to save my life, and perhaps you will never regret it.
You know
how much I love you!*

(He kisses her hand.)

Pamela

I know that you have told me so; but you treat me—

Jules

As my deliverer.

Pamela

*You wrote to me—and your letter has filled me with trouble—I
know
neither who you are—*

Joseph (from the outer room)

*Mademoiselle, I am in the garret. I have looked over the
whole roof.*

Jules

He is coming back—Where can I hide?

Pamela

But you must not stay here!

Jules

You wish to ruin me, Pamela!

Pamela

Look, hide yourself there!

(She points to the cranny under the sloping roof.)

Joseph (returning)

Are you alone, mademoiselle?

Pamela

No; for are not you here?

Joseph

I heard something like the voice of a man. The voice came from below.

Pamela

Nonsense, more likely it came from above—Look down the staircase—

Joseph

Oh! But I am sure—

Pamela

Nonsense. Leave me, sir; I wish to be alone.

Joseph

Alone, with a man's voice?

Pamela

I suppose you don't believe me?

Joseph

But I heard it plain enough.

Pamela

You heard nothing.

Joseph

Ah! Pamela!

Pamela

If you prefer to believe the sounds which you say reached your ears,

rather than the words I speak, you would make a very bad husband. That

is quite sufficient for me.

Joseph

That doesn't prove that I did not hear—

Pamela

Since I can't convince you, you can believe what you like. Yes! you

did hear a voice, the voice of a young man, who is in love with me,

and who does whatever I wish—He disappears when he is asked,
and
comes when he is wanted. And now what are you waiting for? Do
you
think that while he is here, your presence can be anything
but
disagreeable to us? Go and ask my father and mother what his
name is.
He must have told them when he came up stairs—he, and the
voice you
heard.

Joseph
Mlle. Pamela, forgive a poor youth who is mad with love. It
is not
only my heart that I have lost, but my head also, when I
think of you.
I know that you are just as good as you are beautiful, I know
that you
have in your soul more treasures of sweetness than you ever
show, and
so I know that you are right, and were I to hear ten voices,
were I to
see ten men here, I would care nothing about it. But one—

Pamela
Well, what of it?

Joseph
A single one—that is what wounds me. But I must be off; it
seems
funny that I should have said all that to you. I know quite
well that
there is no one here but you. Till we meet again, Mlle.
Pamela; I am
going—I trust you.

Pamela (aside)
He evidently does not feel quite sure.

Joseph (aside)
There is some one here! I will run down and tell the whole
matter to
her father and mother. (Aloud) Adieu, Mlle. Pamela. (Exit.)

SCENE SECOND

Pamela and Jules.

Pamela

M. Adolph, you see to what you are exposing me. That poor lad is a

workman, a most kind-hearted fellow; he has an uncle rich enough to

set him up in business; he wishes to marry me, and in one moment I

have lost my prospects—and for whom? I do not know you, and from the

manner in which you imperil the reputation of a young girl who has no

capital but her good behavior, I conclude that you think you have the

right to do so. You are rich and you make sport of poor people!

Jules

No, my dear Pamela. I know who you are, and I take you at your true

value. I love you, I am rich, and we will never leave one another. My

traveling carriage is with a friend, at the gate of St. Denis; we will

proceed on foot to catch it; I intend embarking for England. You must

come with me. I cannot explain my intentions now, for the least delay

may prove fatal to me.

Pamela

What do you mean?

Jules

You shall see—

Pamela

Are you in your right senses, M. Adolph? After having followed me

about for a month, seen me twice at a dance, written me

several

declarations, such as young men of your sort write to any and every

woman, you point-blank propose an elopement!

Jules

Oh, I beg of you, don't delay an instant! You'll repent of this for

the rest of your life, and you will see too late what mischief you have done.

Pamela

But, my dear sir, you can perhaps explain yourself in a couple of words.

Jules

No,—for the secret is a matter of life and death to several persons.

Pamela

If it were only to save your life, whoever you are, I would do a good

deal; but what assistance could I be to you in your flight! Why do you

want to take me to England?

Jules

What a child you are! No one, of course, would suspect anything of two

runaway lovers! And, let me tell you, I love you well enough to

disregard everything else, and even to brave the anger of my parents—

Once we are married at Gretna Green—

Pamela

Oh, mon Dieu! I am quite non-plussed! Here's a handsome young man

urges you—implores you—and talks of marriage—

Jules

They are mounting the staircase—I am lost!—You have betrayed me!—

Pamela

M. Adolph, you alarm me! What is going to happen? Wait a moment, I will go and see.

Jules

In any case, take and keep this twenty thousand francs. It will be safer with you than in the hands of the police—I have only half an hour longer and all will be over.

Pamela

There is nothing to fear—It is only my father and mother.

Jules

You have the kindness of an angel. I trust my fate with you. But you must know that both of us must leave this house at once; and I swear on my honor, that nothing but good shall result to you.

(He hides again under the roof.)

SCENE THIRD

Pamela, M. Giraud and Mme. Giraud.

Pamela (who stands in such a way as to prevent her parents from entering fully into the room; aside)
Evidently here is a man in danger—and a man who loves me—two reasons why I should be interested in him.

Mme. Giraud

How is this, Pamela—you the solace of all our misfortunes, the prop of our old age, our only hope!

Giraud

A girl brought up on the strictest principles.

Mme. Giraud

Keep quiet, Giraud! You don't know what you are talking about.

Giraud

Certainly, Madame Giraud.

Mme. Giraud

And besides all this, Pamela, your example was cited in all the

neighborhood as a girl who'd be useful to your parents in their declining years!

Giraud

And worthy to receive the prize of virtue!

Pamela

Then what is the meaning of all these reproaches?

Mme. Giraud

Joseph has just told us that you had a man hidden in your room.

Giraud

Yes—he heard the voice.

Mme. Giraud

Silence, Giraud!—Pamela—pay no attention to your father—

Pamela

And do you, mother, pay no attention to Joseph.

Giraud

What did I tell you on the stairs, Madame Giraud? Pamela knows how we

count upon her. She wishes to make a good match as much on our account

as on her own; her heart bleeds to see us porters, us, the authors of

her life! She is too sensible to blunder in this matter. Is it not so,

my child, you would not deceive your father?

Mme. Giraud

There is nobody here, is there, my love? For a young working-girl to

have any one in her room, at ten o'clock at night—well—she runs a risk of losing—

Pamela

But it seems to me that if I had any one you would have seen him on his way up.

Giraud

She is right.

Mme. Giraud

She does not answer straight out. Please open the door of this room.

Pamela

Mother, stop! Do not come in here,—you shall not come in here!—

Listen to me; as I love you, mother, and you, father, I have nothing

to reproach myself with!—and I swear to it before God!—Do not in a

moment withdraw from your daughter the confidence which you have had

in her for so long a time.

Mme. Giraud

But why not tell us?

Pamela (aside)

Impossible! If they were to see this young man every one would soon

know all about it.

Giraud (interrupting her)

We are your father and mother, and we must see!

Pamela

For the first time in my life, I refuse to obey you!—But you force me

to it!—These lodgings are rented by me from the earnings of

my work!

I am of age and mistress of my own actions.

Mme. Giraud

Oh, Pamela! Can this be you, on whom we have placed all our hopes?

Giraud

You will ruin yourself!—and I shall remain a porter to the end of my days.

Pamela

You needn't be afraid of that! Well—I admit that there is some one

here; but silence! You must go down stairs again to your lodge. You

must tell Joseph that he does not know what he is talking about, that

you have searched everywhere, that there is no one in my lodging; you

must send him away—then you shall see this young man; you shall learn

what I purpose doing. But you must keep everything the most profound secret.

Giraud

Unhappy girl! What do you take us for? (He sees the banknotes on the

table.) Ah! what is this? Banknotes!

Mme. Giraud

Banknotes! (She recoils from Pamela.) Pamela, where did you get them?

Pamela

I will tell you when I write.

Giraud

When you write! She must be going to elope!

SCENE FOURTH

The same persons, and Joseph Binet.

Joseph (entering)

I was quite sure that there was something wrong about him!—He is a ringleader of thieves! The gendarmes, the magistrate, all the excitement she showed mean something—and now the house is surrounded!

Jules (appearing)

I am lost!

Pamela

I have done all that I could!

Giraud

And you, sir, who are you?

Joseph

Are you a—?

Mme. Giraud

Speak!

Jules

But for this idiot, I would have escaped! You will now have the ruin of an innocent man on your consciences.

Pamela

M. Adolph, are you innocent?

Jules

I am!

Pamela

What shall we do? (Pointing to the dormer window.) You can elude their pursuit that way out.

(She opens the dormer window and finds the police agents on the roof outside.)

Jules

*It is too late. All you can do is to confirm my statement.
You must*

*declare that I am your daughter's lover; that I have asked
you to give*

*her in marriage to me; that I am of age; that my name is
Adolph*

Durand, son of a rich business man of Marseilles.

Giraud

*He offers her lawful love and wealth!—Young man, I willingly
take you*

under my protection.

SCENE FIFTH

The same persons, a sheriff, a police officer and gendarmes.

Giraud

*Sir, what right have you to enter an occupied dwelling—the
domicile*

of a peaceable young girl?

Joseph

Yes, what right have you—?

The sheriff

*Young man, don't you worry about our right!—A few moments ago
you*

*were very friendly and slowed us where the unknown might be
found, but*

now you have suddenly changed your tune.

Pamela

But what are you looking for? What do you want?

The sheriff

You seem to be well aware that we are looking for somebody.

Giraud

Sir, my daughter has no one with her but her future husband,

M.—

The sheriff
Rousseau.

Pamela
M. Adolph Durand.

Giraud
Rousseau I don't know.—The gentleman I refer to is M. Adolph Durand.

Mme. Giraud
Son of a respectable merchant of Marseilles.

Joseph
Ah! you have been deceiving me! Ah!—That is the secret of your coldness, and he is—

The sheriff (to the officer of the police)
This does not seem to be the man?

The officer
Oh, yes, I am sure of it! (to the gendarmes) Carry out my orders.

Jules
Monsieur, I am the victim of some mistake; my name is not Jules Rousseau.

The officer
Oh! but you know his first name, which none of us has as yet mentioned.

Jules
But I heard some one say it. Here are my papers, which are perfectly correct.

The sheriff
Let me see them, please.

Giraud

Gentlemen, I assure you and declare to you—

The officer

If you go on in this way, and wish to make us believe that this gentleman is Adolph Durand, son of a merchant of—

Mme. Giraud

Of Marseilles—

The officer

You may all be arrested as his accomplices, locked up in jail this

evening, and implicated in an affair from which you will not easily

get off. Have you any regard for the safety of your neck?

Giraud

A great deal!

The officer

Very well! Hold your tongue, then.

Mme. Giraud

Do hold your tongue, Giraud!

Pamela

Merciful heaven! Why did I not believe him at once!

The sheriff (to his agents)

Search the gentleman!

(The agent takes out Jules' pocket handkerchief.)

The officer

It is marked with a J and an R. My dear sir, you are not very clever!

Joseph

What can he have done? Have you anything to do with it, mademoiselle?

Pamela

You are the sole cause of the trouble. Never speak to me again!

The officer

Monsieur, here we have the check for your dinner—you dined at the

Palais Royal. While you were there you wrote a letter in pencil. One

of your friends brought the letter here. His name was M. Adolph

Durand, and he lent you his passport. We are certain of your identity;

you are M. Jules Rousseau.

Joseph

The son of the rich M. Rousseau, whose house we are furnishing?

The sheriff

Hold your tongue!

The officer

You must come with us.

Jules

Certainly, monsieur. (To Giraud and his wife) Forgive the annoyance I

have caused you—and you, Pamela, do not forget me! If you do not see

me again, you may keep what I gave into your hands, and may it bring

you happiness!

Giraud

O Lord!

Pamela

Poor Adolph!

The sheriff (to his agents)

Remain here. We are going to search this attic, and question every one

of these people.

Joseph (with a gesture of horror)

Ah!—she prefers a criminal to me!

(Jules is put in charge of the agents.)

Curtain to the First Act.

ACT II

SCENE FIRST

(The setting is a drawing-room in the Rousseau mansion. Antoine is looking through the newspapers.)

Antoine and Justine.

Justine

Well, Antoine, have you read the papers?

Antoine

I am reading them. Isn't it a pity that we servants cannot learn, excepting through the papers, what is going on in the trial of M.

Jules?

Justine

And yet the master and mistress and Mme. du Brocard, their sister, know nothing. M. Jules has been for three months—in what do they call it?—in close confinement.

Antoine

The arrest of the young man has evidently attracted great attention—

Justine

It seems absurd to think that a young man who had nothing to do but amuse himself, who would some day inherit his aunt's income of twenty thousand francs, and his father's and mother's fortune, which is quite

double that amount, should be mixed up in a conspiracy!

Antoine

I admire him for it, for they were plotting to bring back the emperor!

You may cause my throat to be cut if you like. We are alone here—you

don't belong to the police; long live the emperor! say I.

Justine

For mercy's sake, hold your tongue, you old fool!—If any one heard

you, you would get us all arrested.

Antoine

I am not afraid of that, thank God! The answers I made to the magistrate were non-committal; I never compromised M. Jules, like the

traitors who informed against him.

Justine

Mme. du Brocard with all her immense savings ought to be able to buy

him off.

Antoine

Oh, nonsense! Since the escape of Lavalette such a thing is impossible! They have become extremely particular at the gates of the

prison, and they were never particularly accommodating. M. Jules will

have to take his dose you see; he will be a martyr. I shall go and see

him executed.

(Some one rings. Exit Antoine.)

Justine

We will go and see him! When one has known a condemned man I don't see

how they can have the heart to—As for me I shall go to the Court of

Assizes. I feel, poor boy, I owe him that!

SCENE SECOND

Dupre, Antoine and Justine.

Antoine (aside, as he ushers in Dupre)

Ah! The lawyer. (Aloud) Justine, go and tell madame that Monsieur

Dupre is waiting. (Aside) The lawyer is a hard nut to crack, I'm

thinking. (Aloud) Sir, is there any hope of saving our poor M. Jules?

Dupre

I perceive that you are very fond of your young master?

Antoine

Naturally enough!

Dupre

What would you do to save him?

Antoine

Anything, sir!

Dupre

That means nothing.

Antoine

Nothing?—I will give whatever evidence you like.

Dupre

*If you are caught in contradicting yourself and convicted of perjury,
do you know what you run the risk of?*

Antoine

No, sir.

Dupre

The galleys.

Antoine

That is rather severe, sir.

Dupre

You would prefer to serve him without compromising yourself?

Antoine

Is there any other way?

Dupre

No.

Antoine

Well! I'll run the risk of the galleys.

Dupre (aside)

What devotion is here!

Antoine

My master would be sure to settle a pension on me.

Justine

Here is madame.

SCENE THIRD

The same persons and Madame Rousseau.

Mme. Rousseau (to Dupre)

Ah! Monsieur, we have been impatiently expecting this visit.

(To

Antoine) Antoine! Quick, inform my husband. (To Dupre) Sir, I trust in

your efforts, alone.

Dupre

You may be sure, madame, that I shall employ every energy—

Mme. Rousseau

Oh! Thank you! But of course Jules is not guilty. To think of him as a

conspirator! Poor child, how could any one suspect him, who trembles

before me at the slightest reproach—me, his mother! Ah, monsieur,

promise that you will restore him to me!

Rousseau (entering the room)

(To Antoine) Yes, carry the letter to General de Verby. I shall wait

for him here. (To Dupre) I am glad to see you, my dear M. Dupre—

Dupre

The battle will doubtless begin to-morrow; to-day preparations are being made, and the indictment drawn.

Rousseau

Has my poor Jules made any admissions?

Dupre

He has denied everything, and has played to perfection the part of an

innocent man; but we are not able to oppose any testimony to that

which is being brought against him.

Rousseau

Ah! Monsieur, save my son, and the half of my fortune shall be yours!

Dupre

If I had every half of a fortune that has been promised to me, I

should be too rich for anything.

Rousseau

Do you question the extent of my gratitude?

Dupre

We will wait till the result of the trial is known, sir.

Mme. Rousseau

Take pity on a poor mother!

Dupre

Madame, I swear to you nothing so much excites my curiosity and my

sympathy, as a genuine sentiment. And at Paris sincerity is

so rare

that I cannot be indifferent to the grief of a family
threatened with
the loss of an only son. You may therefore rely upon me.

Rousseau

Ah! Monsieur!

SCENE FOURTH

The same persons, General de Verby and Madame du Brocard.

Mme. du Brocard (showing in De Verby)
Come in, my dear general.

De Verby (bowing to Rousseau)
Monsieur—I simply came to learn—

Rousseau (presenting Dupre to De Verby)
General, M. Dupre.

(Dupre and De Verby exchange bows.)

Dupre (aside, while De Verby talks with Rousseau)
He is general of the antechamber, holding the place merely
through the
influence of his brother, the lord chamberlain; he doesn't
seem to me
to have come here without some object.

De Verby (to Dupre)
I understand, sir, that you are engaged for the defence of M.
Jules
Rousseau in this deplorable affair—

Dupre
Yes, sir, it is a deplorable affair, for the real culprits
are not in
prison; thus it is that justice rages fiercely against the
rank and
file, but the chiefs are always passed by. You are General
Vicomte de
Verby, I presume?

De Verby

Simple General Verby—I do not take the title—my opinions of course.

—Doubtless you are acquainted with the evidence in this case?

Dupre

I have been in communication with the accused only for the last three days.

De Verby

And what do you think of the affair?

All

Yes, tell us.

Dupre

According to my experience of the law courts, I believe it possible to

obtain important revelations by offering commutation of sentence to the condemned.

De Verby

The accused are all men of honor.

Rousseau

But—

Dupre

Characters sometime change at the prospect of the scaffold, especially when there is much at stake.

De Verby (aside)

A conspiracy ought not to be entered upon excepting with penniless accomplices.

Dupre

I shall induce my client to tell everything.

Rousseau

Of course.

Mme. du Brocard
Certainly.

Mme. Rousseau
He ought to do so.

De Verby (anxiously)
I presume there is no other way of escape for him?

Dupre
None whatever; it can be proved that he was of the number of those who had begun to put in execution the plot.

De Verby
I would rather lose my head than my honor.

Dupre
I should consider which of the two was worth more.

De Verby
You have your views in the matter.

Rousseau
Those are mine.

Dupre
And they are the opinions of the majority. I have seen many things done by men to escape the scaffold. There are people who push others to the front, who risk nothing, and yet reap all the fruits of success. Have such men any honor? Can one feel any obligation towards them?

De Verby
No, they are contemptible wretches.

Dupre (aside)
He has well said it. This is the fellow who has ruined poor Jules! I must keep my eye on him.

SCENE FIFTH

The same persons, Antoine and Jules (the latter led in by police agents.)

Antoine

Sir, a carriage stopped at the door. Several men got out. M. Jules is with them; they are bringing him in.

M. and Mme. Rousseau
My son!

Mme. du Brocard
My nephew!

Dupre
Yes, I see what it is—doubtless a search-warrant. They wish to look over his papers.

Antoine
Here he is.

(Jules appears in the centre, followed by the police and a magistrate; he rushes up to his mother.)

Jules
O mother! My good mother! (He embraces his mother.) Ah! I see you once more! (To Mme. du Brocard) Dear aunt!

Mme. Rousseau
My poor child! Come! Come—close to me; they will not dare—(To the police, who approach her) Leave him, leave him here!

Rousseau (rushing towards the police)
Be kind enough—

Dupre (to the magistrate)

Monsieur!

Jules

My dear mother, calm yourself! I shall soon be free; yes, be quite sure of that, and we will not part again.

Antoine (to Rousseau)

Sir, they wish to visit M. Jules's room.

Rousseau (to the magistrate)

In a moment, monsieur. I will go with you myself. (To Dupre, pointing to Jules) Do not leave him!

(He goes out conducting the magistrate, who makes a sign to the police to keep guard on Jules.)

Jules (seizing the hand of De Verby)

Ah, general! (To Dupre) And how good and generous of you, M. Dupre, to come here and comfort my mother. (In a low voice) Ah! conceal from her my danger. (Aloud, looking at his mother) Tell her the truth. Tell her that she has nothing to fear.

Dupre

I will tell her that it is in her power to save you.

Mme. Rousseau

In my power?

Mme. du Brocard

How can that be?

Dupre (to Mme. Rousseau)

By imploring him to disclose the names of those who have led him on.

De Verby (to Dupre)

Monsieur!

Mme. Rousseau

Yes, and you ought to do it. I, your mother, demand it of you.

Mme. du Brocard

Oh, certainly! My nephew shall tell everything. He has been led on by people who now abandon him to his fate, and he in his turn ought—

De Verby (in a low voice to Dupre)

What, sir! Would you advise your client to betray—?

Dupre (quickly)

Whom?

De Verby (in a troubled voice)

But—can't we find some other method? M. Jules knows what a man of high spirit owes to himself.

Dupre (aside)

He is the man—I felt sure of it!

Jules (to his mother and aunt)

Never, though I should die for it—never will I compromise any one else.

(De Verby shows his pleasure at this declaration.)

Mme. Rousseau

Ah! my God! (Looking at the police.) And there is no chance of our helping him to escape here!

Mme. du Brocard

No! that is out of the question.

Antoine (coming into the room)

M. Jules, they are asking for you.

Jules

I am coming!

Mme. Rousseau

Ah! I cannot let you go.

(She turns to the police with a supplicating look.)

Mme. du Brocard (to Dupre, who scrutinizes De Verby)

M. Dupre, I have thought that it would be a good thing—

Dupre (interrupting her)

Later, madame, later.

(He leads her to Jules, who goes out with his mother,
followed by the
agents.)

SCENE SIXTH

Dupre and De Verby.

De Verby (aside)

These people have hit upon a lawyer who is rich, without
ambition—and
eccentric.

Dupre (crossing the stage and gazing at De Verby, aside)

Now is my time to learn your secret. (Aloud) You are very
much
interested in my client, monsieur?

De Verby

Very much indeed.

Dupre

I have yet to understand what motive could have led him,
young, rich
and devoted to pleasure as he is, to implicate himself in a
conspiracy—

De Verby

The passion for glory.

Dupre

Don't talk in that way to a lawyer who for twenty years has
practiced

in the courts; who has studied men and affairs well enough to know

that the finest motives are only assumed as a disguise for trumpery

passions, and has never yet met a man whose heart was free from the

calculations of self-interest.

De Verby

Do you ever take up a case without charging anything?

Dupre

I often do so; but I never act contrary to my convictions.

De Verby

I understand that you are rich?

Dupre

I have some fortune. Without it, in the world as at present constituted, I should be on the straight road for the poor-house.

De Verby

It is then from conviction, I suppose, that you have undertaken the

defence of young Rousseau?

Dupre

Certainly. I believe him to be the dupe of others in a higher station,

and I like those who allow themselves to be duped from generous

motives and not from self-interest; for in these times the dupe is

often as greedy after gain as the man who exploits him.

De Verby

You belong, I perceive, to the sect of misanthropes.

Dupre

I do not care enough for mankind to hate them, for I have never yet

met any one I could love. I am contented with studying my fellow-men;

for I see that they are all engaged in playing each, with

more or less

success, his own little comedy. I have no illusion about anything, it

is true, but I smile at it all like a spectator who sits in a theatre

to be amused. One thing I never do; I hiss at nothing; for I have not

sufficient feeling about things for that.

De Verby (aside)

How is it possible to influence such a man? (Aloud) Nevertheless,

monsieur, you must sometimes need the services of others?

Dupre

Never!

De Verby

But you are sometimes sick?

Dupre

Then I like to be alone. Moreover, at Paris, anything can be bought,

even attendance on the sick; believe me I live because it is my duty

to do so. I have tested everything—charity, friendship, unselfish

devotion. Those who have received benefits have disgusted me with the

doing of kindnesses. Certain philanthropists have made me feel a

loathing for charity. And of all humbugs that of sentiment is the most

hateful.

De Verby

And what of patriotism, monsieur?

Dupre

That is a very trifling matter, since the cry of humanity has been

raised.

De Verby (somewhat discouraged)

And so you take Jules Rousseau for a young enthusiast?

Dupre

No, sir, nothing of the sort. He presents a problem which I have to

solve, and with your assistance I shall reach the solution.

(De Verby

changes countenance.) Come, let us speak candidly. I believe that you

know something about all this.

De Verby

What do you mean, sir?

Dupre

You can save the young man.

De Verby

I? What can I do?

Dupre

You can give testimony which Antoine will corroborate—

De Verby

I have reasons for not appearing as a witness.

Dupre

Just so. You are one of the conspirators!

De Verby

Monsieur!

Dupre

It is you who have led on this poor boy.

De Verby

Monsieur, this language—!

Dupre

Don't attempt to deceive me, but tell me how you managed to gain this

bad influence over him? He is rich, he is in need of nothing.

De Verby

Listen!—If you say another word—

Dupre

Oh! my life is of no consideration with me!

De Verby

Sir, you know very well that Jules will get off; and that if he does

not behave properly, he will lose, through your fault, the chance of

marriage with my niece, and thus the succession to the title of my

brother, the Lord Chamberlain.

Dupre

Ah, that's what he was after, then! He's like all the rest of the

schemers. Now consider, sir, what I am going to propose to you. You

have powerful friends, and it is your duty—

De Verby

My duty! I do not understand you, sir.

Dupre

You have been able to effect his ruin, and can you not bring about his

release? (Aside) I have him there.

De Verby

I shall give my best consideration to the matter.

Dupre

Don't consider for a moment that you can escape me.

De Verby

A general who fears no danger can have no fear of a lawyer—

Dupre

As you will!

(Exit De Verby, who jostles against Joseph.)

SCENE SEVENTH

Dupre and Joseph Binet.

Joseph

I heard only yesterday, monsieur, that you were engaged for the

defence of M. Jules Rousseau; I have been to your place, and have

waited for you until I could wait no later. This morning I found that

you had left your home, and as I am working for this house, a happy

inspiration sent me here. I thought you would be coming here, and I

waited for you—

Dupre

What do you want with me?

Joseph

I am Joseph Binet.

Dupre

Well, proceed.

Joseph

Let me say without offence, sir, that I have fourteen hundred francs

of my own—quite my own!—earned sou by sou. I am a journeyman upholsterer, and my uncle, Du Mouchel, a retired wine merchant, has plenty of the metal.

Dupre

Speak out openly! What is the meaning of this mysterious preamble?

Joseph

Fourteen hundred francs is of course a mere trifle, and they say that

lawyers have to be well paid, and that it is because they are well

paid that there are so many of them. I should have done better if I

had been a lawyer—then she would have married me!

Dupre

Are you crazy?

Joseph

Not at all. I have here my fourteen hundred francs; take them, sir—no humbug! They are yours.

Dupre

And on what condition?

Joseph

You must save M. Jules—I mean, of course, from death—and you must

have him transported. I don't want him to be put to death; but he must

go abroad. He is rich, and he will enjoy himself. But save his life.

Procure a sentence of simple transportation, say for fifteen years,

and my fourteen hundred francs are yours. I will give them to you

gladly, and I will moreover make you an office chair below the market

price. There now!

Dupre

What is your object in speaking to me in this way?

Joseph

My object? I want to marry Pamela. I want to have my little Pamela.

Dupre

Pamela?

Joseph

Pamela Giraud.

Dupre

What connection has Pamela Giraud with Jules Rousseau?

Joseph

Well I never! Why! I thought that advocates were paid for learning and

knowing everything. But you don't seem to know anything, sir.

I am not

surprised that there are those who say advocates are know-nothings.

But I should like to have back my fourteen hundred francs. Pamela is

accused, that is to say, she accuses me of having betrayed his head to

the executioner, and you will understand that if after all he escapes,

and is transported, I can marry, can wed Pamela; and as the transported man will not be in France, I need fear no disturbance in

my home. Get him fifteen years; that is nothing; fifteen years for

traveling and I shall have time to see my children grow up, and my

wife old enough—you understand—

Dupre (aside)

He is candid, at any rate—Those who make their calculations aloud and

in such evident excitement are not the worst of people.

Joseph

I say! Do you know the proverb—"A lawyer who talks to himself is like

a pastry cook who eats his own wares,"—eh, sir?

Dupre

I understand you to say that Pamela is in love with M. Jules?

Joseph

Ah! I see, you understand matters.

Dupre

They used frequently to meet I suppose?

Joseph

Far too frequently! Oh! if I had only known it, I would have put a

stop to it!

Dupre

Is she pretty?

Joseph

Who?—Pamela?—My eye! My Pamela! She is as pretty as the Apollo

Belvidere!

Dupre

Keep your fourteen hundred francs, my friend, and if you have courage,

you and your Pamela, you will be able to help me in effecting his

deliverance; for the question is absolutely whether we must let him go

to the scaffold, or save him from it.

Joseph

I beg you, sir, do not think of saying one word to Pamela; she is in despair.

Dupre

Nevertheless you must bring it about that I see her this morning.

Joseph

I will send word to her through her parents.

Dupre

Ah! she has a father and mother living then? (Aside) This will cost a

lot of money. (Aloud) Who are they?

Joseph

They are respectable porters.

Dupre

That is good.

Joseph

Old Giraud is a ruined tailor.

Dupre

Very well, go and inform them of my intended visit, and above all

things preserve the utmost secrecy, or M. Jules will be sacrificed.

Joseph
I shall be dumb.

Dupre
And let it be thought that we have never met.

Joseph
We have never seen each other.

Dupre
Now go.

Joseph
I am going.

(He mistakes the door.)

Dupre
This is the way.

Joseph
This is the way, great advocate—but let me give you a bit of advice—
a slight taste of transportation will not do him any harm; in fact, it
will teach him to leave the government in peace. (Exit.)

SCENE EIGHTH

Rousseau, Madame Rousseau, Madame du Brocard (attended by Justine) and
Dupre.

Mme. Rousseau
Poor child! What courage he shows!

Dupre
I hope to save him for you, madame; but it cannot be done without
making great sacrifices.

Rousseau

Sir, the half of our fortune is at your disposal.

Mme. du Brocard
And the half of mine.

Dupre
It is always the half of some fortune or other. I am going to try to
do my duty—afterwards, you must do yours; we shall have to make great
efforts. You, madame, must rouse yourself, for I have great hopes.

Mme. Rousseau
Ah! sir, what can you mean?

Dupre
A little time ago, your son was a ruined man; at the present moment, I
believe he can be saved.

Mme. Rousseau
What must we do?

Mme. du Brocard
What do you ask?

Rousseau
You may be sure we will do as you require.

Dupre
I feel certain you will. This is my plan which will undoubtedly
succeed with the jury. Your son had an intrigue with a certain
working-girl, Pamela Giraud, the daughter of a porter.

Mme. du Brocard
What low people!

Dupre
Yet you will have to humble yourselves to them. Your son was always
with this young girl, and in this point lies the sole hope of his

deliverance. The very evening on which the public prosecutor avers

that he attended a meeting of the conspirators, he was possibly

visiting her. If this is a fact, if she declares that he remained with

her that night, if her father and her mother, if the rival of Jules

confirm the testimony—we shall then have ground for hope. When the

choice has to be made between a sentence of guilty and an alibi, the

jury prefers the alibi.

Mme. Rousseau (aside)

Ah! sir, you bring back life to me.

Rousseau

Sir, we owe you a debt of eternal gratitude.

Dupre (looking at them)

What sum of money must I offer to the daughter, to the father and to

the mother?

Mme. du Brocard

Are they poor?

Dupre

They are, but the matter concerns their honor.

Mme. du Brocard

Oh, she is only a working-girl!

Dupre (ironically)

It ought to be done very cheaply.

Rousseau

What do you think?

Dupre

I think that you are bargaining for the life of your son.

Mme. du Brocard

Well, M. Dupre, I suppose you may go as high as—

Mme. Rousseau
As high as—

Dupre
As high as—

Rousseau
Upon my word, I don't understand why you hesitate—and you must offer,
sir, whatever sum you consider suitable.

Dupre
Just so, you leave it to my discretion. But what compensation do you
offer her if she restores your son to you at the sacrifice of her
honor? For possibly he has made love to her.

Mme. Rousseau
He shall marry her. I come from the people myself, and I am no
marchioness.

Mme. du Brocard
What do you mean by that? You are forgetting Mlle. de Verby.

Mme. Rousseau
Sister, my son's life must be saved.

Dupre (aside)
Here we have the beginning of a comedy and the last which I wish to
see; but I must keep them to their word. (Aloud) Perhaps it would be
well if you secretly paid a visit to the young girl.

Mme. Rousseau
Oh, yes, I should like to go to see her—to implore her— (she rings)
Justine! Antoine! Quick! Order the carriage! At once—

Antoine
Yes, madame.

Mme. Rousseau

Sister, will you go with me? Ah, Jules my poor son!

Mme. du Brocard

They are bringing him back.

SCENE NINTH

*The same persons, Jules (brought in by the police), and later
De Verby.*

Jules (kissing his mother)

O mother!—I will not say good-bye; I shall be back very soon.

(Rousseau and Mme. du Brocard embrace Jules.)

De Verby (going up to Dupre)

*I will do, monsieur, what you have asked of me. One of my
friends, M.*

*Adolph Durand, who facilitated the flight of our dear Jules,
will*

*testify that his friend was altogether taken up with a
grisette, whom*

*he loved passionately, and with whom he was taking measures
to elope.*

Dupre

*That is enough; success now depends upon the way we set about
things.*

The magistrate (to Jules)

We must be going, monsieur.

Jules

I will follow you. Be of good courage, mother!

*(He bids farewell to Rousseau and Dupre; De Verby signs to
him to be
cautious.)*

Mme. Rousseau (to Jules, as he is being led away)

Jules! Jules! Do not give up hope—we are going to save you!

(The police lead Jules away.)

Curtain to the Second Act.

ACT III

SCENE FIRST

(The stage represents the room of Pamela.)

Pamela, Giraud and Madame Giraud.

(Pamela is standing near her mother, who is knitting; Giraud is at work at a table on the left.)

Mme. Giraud

The fact of the matter is this, my poor daughter; I do not mean to reproach you, but you are the cause of all our trouble.

Giraud

No doubt about it! We came to Paris because in the country tailoring is no sort of a business, and we had some ambition for you, our

Pamela, such a sweet, pretty little thing as you were. We said to each

other: "We will go into service; I will work at my trade; we will give

a good position to our child; and as she will be good, industrious and

pretty, we can take care of our old age by marrying her well."

Pamela

O father!

Mme. Giraud

Half of our plans were already carried out.

Giraud

Yes, certainly. We had a good position; you made as fine flowers as
any gardener could grow; and Joseph Binet, your neighbor, was
to be
the husband of our choice.

Mme. Giraud

Instead of all this, the scandal which has arisen in the
house has
caused the landlord to dismiss us; the talk of the
neighborhood was
incessant, for the young man was arrested in your room.

Pamela

And yet I have been guilty of nothing!

Giraud

Come, now, we know that well enough! Do you think if it were
otherwise

that we would stay near you? And that I would embrace you?
After all,

Pamela, there is nothing like a father and a mother! And when
the

whole world is against you, if a girl can look into her
parents' face

without a blush it is enough.

SCENE SECOND

The same persons and Joseph Binet.

Mme. Giraud

Well, well! Here is Joseph Binet.

Pamela

M. Binet, what are you doing here? But for your want of
common-sense,

M. Jules would not have been found here.

Joseph

I am come to tell you about him.

Pamela

What! Really? Well, let us hear, Joseph.

Joseph

Ah! you won't send me away now, will you? I have seen his lawyer, and

I have offered him all that I possess if he would get him off!

Pamela

Do you mean it?

Joseph

Yes. Would you be satisfied if he was merely transported?

Pamela

Ah! you are a good fellow, Joseph, and I see that you love me! Let us be friends.

Joseph (aside)

I have good hopes that we shall be.

(A knock at the door is heard.)

SCENE THIRD

The preceding, M. de Verby and Madame du Brocard.

Mme. Giraud (opening the door)

There are some people here!

Giraud

A lady and a gentleman.

Joseph

What did you say?

(Pamela rises from her seat and takes a step toward M. de Verby, who bows to her.)

Mme. du Brocard

Is this Mlle. Pamela Giraud?

Pamela
It is, madame.

De Verby
Forgive us, mademoiselle, for presenting ourselves without
previous
announcement—

Pamela
There is no harm done. May I know the object of this visit?

Mme. du Brocard
And you, good people, are her father and mother?

Mme. Giraud
Yes, madame.

Joseph
She calls them good people—she must be one of the swells.

Pamela
Will you please be seated.

(Mme. Giraud offers them seats.)

Joseph (to Giraud)
My eye! The gentleman has on the ribbon of the Legion of
Honor! He
belongs to high society.

Giraud (looking at De Verby)
By my faith, that's true!

Mme. du Brocard
I am the aunt of M. Jules Rousseau.

Pamela
You, madame? Then this gentleman must be his father?

Mme. du Brocard
He is merely a friend of the family. We are come,
mademoiselle, to ask
a favor of you. (Looking at Binet with embarrassment.) Your
brother?

Giraud
No, madame, just a neighbor of ours.

Mme. du Brocard (to Pamela)
Send him away.

Joseph (aside)
Send him away, indeed. I'd like to know what right she has—

(Pamela makes a sign to Joseph.)

Giraud (to Joseph)
My friend, you had better leave us. It seems this is a private matter.

Joseph
Very well. (Exit.)

SCENE FOURTH

The same persons excepting Binet.

Mme. du Brocard (to Pamela)
You are acquainted with my nephew. I do not intend to reproach you.
Your parents alone have the right.

Mme. Giraud
But, thank God, they have no reason.

Giraud
It is your nephew who has caused all this talk about her, but she is
blameless!

De Verby (interrupting him)
But suppose that we wish her to be guilty?

Pamela
What do you mean, sir?

Giraud and Mme. Giraud

To think of it!

Mme. du Brocard (seizing De Verby's meaning)

Yes, suppose, to save the life of a poor young man—

De Verby

It were necessary to declare that M. Jules Rousseau spent nearly the whole night of the twenty-fourth of August here with you?

Pamela

Ah! sir!

De Verby (to Giraud and his wife)

Yes, suppose it were necessary to testify against your daughter, by alleging this?

Mme. Giraud

I would never say such a thing.

Giraud

What! Insult my child! Sir, I have had all possible troubles. I was

once a tailor, now I am reduced to nothing. I am a porter! But I have

remained a father. My daughter is our sole treasure, the glory of our old age, and you ask us to dishonor her?

Mme. du Brocard

Pray listen to me, sir.

Giraud

No, madame, I will listen to nothing. My daughter is the hope of my gray hairs.

Pamela

Calm yourself, father, I implore you.

Mme. Giraud

Keep quite, Giraud! Do let this lady and gentleman speak!

Mme. du Brocard

A family in deep affliction implores you to save them.

Pamela (aside)

Poor Jules!

De Verby (in a low voice to Pamela)

His fate is in your hands.

Mme. Giraud

We are respectable people and know what it is for parents, for a

mother, to be in despair. But what you ask is out of the question.

(Pamela puts a handkerchief to her eyes.)

Giraud

We must stop this! You see the girl is in tears.

Mme. Giraud

She has done nothing but weep for several days.

Giraud

I know my daughter; she would be capable of going and making the

declaration they ask, in spite of us.

Mme. Giraud

Yes,—for you must see, she loves him, she loves your nephew! And to

save his life—Well! Well! I would have done as much in her place.

Mme. du Brocard

Have compassion on us!

De Verby

Grant this request of ours—

Mme. du Brocard (to Pamela)

If it is true that you love Jules—

Mme. Giraud (leading Giraud up to Pamela)

Did you hear that? Well! Listen to me. She is in love with this youth.

It is quite certain that he also is in love with her. If she should
make a sacrifice like that, as a return, he ought to marry her.

Pamela (with vehemence)
Never! (Aside) These people would not wish it, not they.

De Verby (to Mme. du Brocard)
They are consulting about it.

Mme. du Brocard (in a low voice to De Verby)
It will be absolutely necessary for us to make a sacrifice.
We must
appeal to their interest. It is the only plan!

De Verby
In venturing to ask of you so great a sacrifice, we are quite aware of
the claims that you will have on our gratitude. The family of Jules,
who might have blamed you on account of your relations with him, are,
on the contrary, anxious to discharge the obligations which bind them
to you.

Mme. Giraud
Ah! Did I not tell you so?

Pamela
Can it be possible that Jules—

De Verby
I am authorized to make a promise to you.

Pamela (with emotion)
Oh!

De Verby
Tell me, how much do you ask for the sacrifice required of you?

Pamela (in consternation)
What do you mean? How much—I ask—for saving Jules? What do

you take
me for?

Mme. du Brocard
Ah! Mademoiselle!

De Verby
You misunderstand me.

Pamela
No, it is you who misunderstand us! You are come here, to the house of poor people, and you are quite unaware of what you ask from them. You, madame, ought to know that whatever be the rank or the education of a woman, her honor is her sole treasure! And that which you in your own families guard with so much care, with so much reverence, you actually believe that people here, living in an attic, would be willing to sell! And you have said to yourselves: "Let us offer them money! We need just now the sacrifice of a working-girl's honor!"

Giraud
That is excellent! I recognize my own blood there.

Mme. du Brocard
My dear child, do not be offended! Money is money, after all.

De Verby (addressing Giraud)
Undoubtedly! And six thousand francs for a solid annual income as a price of—a—

Pamela
As the price of a lie! For I must out with it. But thank God I haven't yet lost my self-respect! Good-bye, sir.

(Pamela makes a low bow to Mme. du Brocard, then goes into her bed-chamber.)

De Verby
What is to be done?

Mme. du Brocard
I am quite nonplussed.

Giraud
I quite admit that an income of six thousand francs is no trifle, but
our daughter has a high spirit, you see; she takes after me—

Mme. Giraud
And she will never yield.

SCENE FIFTH

The same persons, Joseph Binet, Dupre and Mme. Rousseau.

Joseph
This way, sir. This way, madame. (Dupre and Mme. Rousseau enter.)
These are the father and mother of Pamela Giraud!

Dupre (to De Verby)
I am very sorry, sir, that you have got here before me!

Mme. Rousseau
My sister has doubtless told you, madame, the sacrifice which we
expect your daughter to make for us. Only an angel would make it.

Joseph
What sacrifice?

Mme. Giraud
It is no business of yours.

De Verby
We have just had an interview with Mlle. Pamela—

Mme. du Brocard

She has refused!

Mme. Rousseau
Oh, heavens!

Dupre
Refused what?

Mme. du Brocard
An income of six thousand francs.

Dupre
I could have wagered on it. To think of offering money!

Mme. du Brocard
But it was the only way—

Dupre
To spoil everything. (To Mme. Giraud) Madame, kindly tell
your
daughter that the counsel of M. Jules Rousseau is here and
desires to
see her.

Mme. Giraud
Oh, as for that you will gain nothing.

Giraud
Either from her or from us.

Joseph
But what is it they want?

Giraud
Hold your tongue.

Mme. du Brocard (to Mme. Giraud)
Madame, offer her—

Dupre
Now, Mme. du Brocard, I must beg you— (To Mme. Giraud) It is
in the
name of the mother of Jules that I ask of you permission to
see your
daughter.

Mme. Giraud

It will be of no use at all, sir! And to think that they point-blank

offered her money when the young man a little time before had spoken

of marrying her!

Mme. Rousseau (with excitement)

Well, why not?

Mme. Giraud (with vehemence)

How was that, madame?

Dupre (seizing the hand of Mme. Giraud)

Come, come! Bring me your daughter.

(Exit Mme. Giraud.)

De Verby and Mme. du Brocard

You have then made up your mind?

Dupre

It is not I, but madame who has made up her mind.

De Verby (questioning Mme. du Brocard)

What has she promised?

Dupre (seeing that Joseph is listening)

Be silent, general; stay for a moment, I beg you, with these ladies.

Here she comes. Now leave us alone, if you please.

(Pamela is brought in by her mother. She makes a curtsey to Mme.

Rousseau, who gazes at her with emotion; then Dupre leads all but

Pamela into the other room; Joseph remains behind.)

Joseph (aside)

I wonder what they mean. They all talk of a sacrifice! And old Giraud

won't say a word to me! Well, I can bide my time. I promised the

advocate that I would give him my fourteen hundred francs,

but before

I do so, I would like to see how he acts with regard to me.

Dupre (going up to Joseph)

Joseph Binet, you must leave the room.

Joseph

And not hear what you say about me?

Dupre

You must go away.

Joseph (aside)

It is evident that they are concealing something from me. (To Dupre) I have prepared her mind; she is much taken with the idea of transportation. Stick to that point.

Dupre

All right! But you must leave the room.

Joseph (aside)

Leave the room! Oh, indeed! Not I.

(Joseph makes as if he had withdrawn, but, quietly returning, hides himself in a closet.)

Dupre (to Pamela)

You have consented to see me, and I thank you for it. I know exactly what has recently taken place here, and I am not going to address you in the same way as you have been recently addressed.

Pamela

Your very presence assures me of that, sir.

Dupre

You are in love with this fine young man, this Joseph?

Pamela

I am aware, sir, that advocates are like confessors!

Dupre

My child, they have to be just as safe confidants. You may tell me everything without reserve.

Pamela

Well, sir, I did love him; that is to say, I thought I loved him, and

I would very willingly have become his wife. I thought that with his

energy Joseph would have made a good business, and that we could lead

together a life of toil. When prosperity came, we would have taken

with us my father and my mother; it was all very clear—it would have

been a united family!

Dupre (aside)

The appearance of this young girl is in her favor! Let us see whether

she is sincere or not. (Aloud) What are you thinking about?

Pamela

I was thinking about these past days, which seemed to me so happy in

comparison with the present. A fortnight ago my head was turned by the

sight of M. Jules; I fell in love with him, as young girls do fall in

love, as I have seen other young girls fall in love with young men—

with a love which would endure everything for those they loved! I used

to say to myself: shall I ever be like that? Well, at this moment I do

not know anything that I would not endure for M. Jules. A few moments

ago they offered me money,—they, from whom I expected such nobleness,

such greatness; and I was disgusted! Money! I have plenty of it, sir!

I have twenty thousand francs! They are here, they are yours! That is

to say, they are his! I have kept them to use in my efforts to save

him, for I have betrayed him, because I doubted him, while he
was so
confident, so sure of me—and I was so distrustful of him!

Dupre

And he gave you twenty thousand francs?

Pamela

Ah, sir! He entrusted them with me. Here they are. I shall
return them
to his family, if he dies; but he shall not die! Tell me? Is
it not
so? You ought to know.

Dupre

My dear child, bear in mind that your whole life, perhaps
your
happiness, depend upon the truthfulness of your answers.
Answer me as
if you stood in the presence of God.

Pamela

I will.

Dupre

You have never loved any one before?

Pamela

Never!

Dupre

You seem to be afraid! Come, I am terrifying you. You are not
giving
me your confidence.

Pamela

Oh, yes I am, sir; I swear I am! Since we have been in Paris,
I have
never left my mother, and I have thought of nothing but my
work and my
duty. I was alarmed and thrown into confusion a few moments
ago, sir,
but you inspire me with confidence, and I can tell you
everything.
Well, I acknowledge it,—I am in love with Jules; he is the

only one I

love, and I would follow him to the end of the world! You told me to

speak as in the presence of God.

Dupre

Well, it is to your heart that I am going to appeal. Do for me what

you have refused to do for others. Tell me the truth! You alone have

the power to save him before the face of justice! You love him,

Pamela; I understand what it would cost you to—

Pamela

To avow my love for him? Would that be sufficient to save him?

Dupre

I will answer for that!

Pamela

Well?

Dupre

My child!

Pamela

Well—he is saved.

Dupre (earnestly)

But—you will be compromised—

Pamela

But after all it is for him.

Dupre (aside)

I never expected it, but I shall not die without having seen with my

own eyes an example of beautiful and noble candor, destitute alike of

self-interest and designing reserve. (Aloud) Pamela, you are a good

and generous girl.

Pamela

To act this way consoles me for many little miseries of life.

Dupre

My child, that is not everything! You are true as steel, you are high-spirited. But in order to succeed it is necessary to have assurance—determination—

Pamela

Oh, sir! You shall see!

Dupre

Do not be over-anxious. Dare to confess everything. Be brave! Imagine that you are before the Court of Assizes, the presiding judge, the public prosecutor, the prisoner at the bar, and me, his advocate; the jury is on one side. The big court-room is filled with people. Do not be alarmed.

Pamela

You needn't fear for me.

Dupre

A court officer brings you in; you have given your name and surname! Then the presiding judge asks you "How long have you known the prisoner, Rousseau?"—What would you answer?

Pamela

The truth!—I met him about a month before his arrest at the Ile d'Amour, Belleville.

Dupre

Who were with him?

Pamela

I noticed no one but him.

Dupre

Did you hear them talk politics?

Pamela (in astonishment)

Oh, sir! The judges must be aware that politics are matters of indifference at the Ile d'Amour.

Dupre

Very good, my child! But you must tell them all you know about Jules Rousseau.

Pamela

Of course. I shall still speak the truth, and repeat my testimony before the police justice. I knew nothing of the conspiracy, and was infinitely surprised when he was arrested in my room; the proof of which is that I feared M. Jules was a thief and afterwards apologized for my suspicion.

Dupre

You must acknowledge that from the time of your first acquaintance with this young man, he constantly came to see you. You must declare—

Pamela

I shall stick to the truth—He never left me alone! He came to see me for love, I received him from friendship, and I resisted him from a sense of duty—

Dupre

And at last?

Pamela (anxiously)

At last?

Dupre

You are trembling! Take care! Just now you promised me to

tell the
truth!

Pamela (aside)
The truth! Oh my God!

Dupre
I also am interested in this young man; but I recoil from a possible
imposture. If he is guilty, my duty bids me defend him, if he is
innocent, his cause shall be mine. Yes, without doubt, Pamela, I am
about to demand from you a great sacrifice, but he needs it.
The visits which Jules made to you were in the evening, and without the
knowledge of your parents.

Pamela
Why no! never!

Dupre
How is this? For in that case there would be no hope for him.

Pamela (aside)
No hope for him! Then either he or I must be ruined. (Aloud)
Sir, do not be alarmed; I felt a little fear because the real danger was not
before my eyes. But when I shall stand before the judges!—when once I
shall see him, see Jules—and feel that his safety depends upon me—

Dupre
That is good, very good. But what is most necessary to be made known
is that on the evening of the twenty-fourth, he came here. If that is
once understood, I shall be successful in saving him; otherwise, I can
answer for nothing. He is lost!

Pamela (murmuring, greatly agitated)

Lost!—Jules lost!—No, no, no!—Better that my own good name be lost!

(Aloud) Yes, he came here on the twenty-fourth. (Aside) God forgive me!

(Aloud) It was my saint's day—my name is Louise Pamela—and he

was kind enough to bring me a bouquet, without the knowledge of my

father or mother; he came in the evening, late. Ah! you need have no

fear, sir—you see I shall tell all. (Aside) And all is a lie!

Dupre

He will be saved! (Rousseau appears) Ah! sir! (running to the door of

the room) Come all of you and thank your deliverer!

SCENE SIXTH

Rousseau, De Verby, Madame du Brocard, Giraud, Madame Giraud, Dupre,
and later Joseph Binet.

All

Does she consent?

Rousseau

You have saved my son. I shall never forget it.

Mme. du Brocard

You have put us under eternal obligations, my child.

Rousseau

My fortune shall be at your disposal.

Dupre

I will not say anything to you, my child! We shall meet again!

Joseph (coming out of the closet)

One moment! One moment! I have heard everything—and do you believe

that I am going to put up with that? I was here in

concealment all the

time. And do you think I am going to let Pamela, whom I have loved and

have wished to make my wife, say all that? (To Dupre) This is the way

you are going to earn my fourteen hundred francs, eh! Well, I shall go

to court myself and testify that the whole thing is a lie.

All

Great heaven!

Dupre

You miserable wretch!

De Verby

If you say a single word—

Joseph

Oh, I am not afraid!

De Verby (to Rousseau and Mme. du Brocard)

He shall never go to court! If necessary, I will have him shadowed,

and I will put men on the watch to prevent him from entering.

Joseph

I'd just like to see you try it!

(Enter a sheriff's officer, who goes up to Dupre.)

Dupre

What do you want?

The sheriff's officer

I am the court officer of the Assizes—Mlle. Pamela Giraud! (Pamela

comes forward.) In virtue of discretionary authority of the presiding

judge, you are summoned to appear before him to-morrow at ten o'clock.

Joseph (to De Verby)

I will go also.

The officer

*The porter has told me that you have here a gentleman called
Joseph
Binet.*

Joseph

Here I am!

The officer

Please take your summons.

Joseph

I told you that I would go!

*(The officer withdraws; every one is alarmed at the threats
of Binet.*

*Dupre tries to speak to him and reason with him, but he
steals away.)*

Curtain to the Third Act.

ACT IV

SCENE FIRST

(The stage represents Madame du Brocard's salon, from which can be seen the Court of Assizes.)

Madame du Brocard, Madame Rousseau, Rousseau, Joseph Binet, Dupre and Justine.

(Dupre is seated reading his note-book.)

Mme. Rousseau
M. Dupre!

Dupre
Yes, madame, the court adjourned after the speech of the prosecuting attorney. And I came over to reassure you personally.

Mme. du Brocard
I told you, sister, that some one was sure to come and keep us informed of things. In my house, here, which is so close to the court house, we are in a favorable position for learning all that goes on at the trial. Ah, M. Dupre! How can we thank you enough! You spoke superbly! (To Justine) Justine, bring in something to drink—Quick!

Rousseau
Sir, your speech— (To his wife) He was magnificent.

Dupre

Sir,—

Joseph (in tears)

Yes, you were magnificent, magnificent!

Dupre

I am not the person you ought to thank, but that child, that Pamela,
who showed such astonishing courage.

Joseph

And didn't I do well?

Mme. Rousseau

And he (pointing to Binet), did he carry out the threat he made to us?

Dupre

No, he took your side.

Joseph

It was your fault! But for you—Ah!—Well—I reached the court house,

having made up my mind to mix up everything; but when I saw all the

people, the judge, the jury, the crowd, and the terrible silence, I

trembled! Nevertheless I screwed up my courage. When I was questioned,

I was just about to answer, when my glance met the eyes of Mlle.

Pamela, which were filled with tears—I felt as if my tongue was

bound. And on the other side I saw M. Jules—a handsome youth, his

fine face conspicuous among them all. His expression was as tranquil

as if he had been a mere spectator. That knocked me out! "Don't be

afraid," said the judge to me. I was absolutely beside myself! I was

afraid of making some mistake; and then I had sworn to keep to the

truth; and then M. Dupre fixed his eye on me. I can't tell you what

that eye seemed to say to me—My tongue seemed twisted up. I broke out

into a sweat—my heart beat hard—and I began to cry, like a fool. You

were magnificent. And then in a moment it was all over. He made me do

exactly what he wanted. This is the way I lied: I said that on the

evening of the twenty-fourth I unexpectedly came to Pamela's room and

found M. Jules there—Yes, at Pamela's, the girl whom I was going to

marry, whom I still love—and our marriage will be the talk of the

whole neighborhood. Never mind, he's a great lawyer! Never mind! (To

Justine) Give me something to drink, will you?

Rousseau, Mme. Rousseau, Mme. du Brocard (To Joseph)

Dear friend! You showed yourself a fine fellow!

Dupre

The energy shown by Pamela makes me hopeful. I trembled for a moment

while she was giving evidence; the prosecuting attorney pressed her

very hard and seemed to doubt her veracity; she grew pale and I

thought she was going to faint.

Joseph

And what must my feelings have been?

Dupre

Her self-sacrifice was wonderful. You don't realize all that she has

undergone for you; I, myself even, was deceived by her; she was her

own accuser, yet all the time was innocent. Only one moment did she

falter; but darting a rapid glance at Jules, she suddenly rallied, a

blush took the place of pallor on her countenance, and we felt that

she had saved her lover; in spite of the risk she was

running, she

repeated once more before all those people the story of her own

disgrace, and then fell weeping into the arms of her mother.

Joseph

Yes, she is a fine girl.

Dupre

But I must leave you; the summing up of the judge will come this

afternoon.

Rousseau

You must be going then.

Dupre

One moment! Do not forget Pamela! That young girl has compromised her

own honor for you and for him.

Joseph

As for me, I don't ask anything, but I have been led to expect—

Mme. du Brocard, Mme. Rousseau

We can never pay our debt of gratitude to you.

Dupre

Very good; come, gentlemen, we must be starting.

(Exeunt Dupre and Rousseau.)

SCENE SECOND

The same persons excepting Dupre and Rousseau.

Mme. du Brocard (stopping Joseph on his way out)
Listen to me!

Joseph

What can I do for you?

Mme. du Brocard

You see in what a state of anxiety we are; don't fail to let us know
the least turn in our favor which the trial makes.

Mme. Rousseau

Yes, keep us well informed on the whole business.

Joseph

You may rest assured of that—But look here, I needn't leave the court

house to do that, I intend to see everything, and to hear everything.

But do you see that window there? My seat is just under it; you watch

that window, and it if he is declared innocent you will see me wave my
handkerchief.

Mme. Rousseau

Do not forget to do so.

Joseph

No danger of that; I am a poor chap, but I know what a mother's heart

is! I am interested in this case, and for you, and for Pamela, I have

said a lot of things! But when you are fond of people you'll do

anything, and then I have been promised something—you may count upon

me. (Exit.)

SCENE THIRD

The same persons excepting Joseph.

Mme. Rousseau

Justine, open this window, and wait for the signal which the young man

has promised to give—Ah! but suppose my boy were condemned!

Mme. du Brocard

M. Dupre has spoken very hopefully about matters.

Mme. Rousseau

But with regard to this good girl, this admirable Pamela—what must we do for her?

Mme. du Brocard

We ought to do something to make her happy! I acknowledge that this

young person is a succor sent from heaven! Only a noble heart could

make the sacrifice that she has made! She deserves a fortune for it!

Thirty thousand francs! That is what she ought to have. Jules owes his

life to her. (Aside) Poor boy, will his life be saved?

(Mme. du Brocard looks toward the window.)

Mme. Rousseau

Well, Justine, do you see anything?

Justine

Nothing, madame.

Mme. Rousseau

Nothing yet! Yes, you are right, sister, it is only the heart that can

prompt such noble actions. I do not know what you and my husband would

think about it, but if we considered what was right, and had full

regard to the happiness of Jules, apart from the brilliant prospect of

an alliance with the family of De Verby, if my son loved her and she

loved my son—it seems to me reasonable—

Mme. du Brocard and Justine

No! No!

Mme. Rousseau

Oh, sister! Say yes! Has she not well deserved it? But there is some

one coming.

(The two women remain in their seats with clasped hands.)

SCENE FOURTH

The same persons and De Verby.

Justine

M. le General de Verby!

Mme. Rousseau and Mme. du Brocard

Ah!

De Verby

Everything is going on well! My presence was no longer necessary, so I

return to you. There are great hopes of your son's acquittal. The

charge of the presiding judge is decidedly in his favor.

Mme. Rousseau (joyfully)

Thank God!

De Verby

Jules has behaved admirably! My brother the Comte de Verby is very

much interested in his favor. My niece looks upon him as a hero, and I

know courage and honorable conduct when I see them. When once this

affair has been settled, we will hasten the marriage.

Mme. Rousseau

We ought to tell you, sir, that we have made certain promises to this

young girl.

Mme. du Brocard

Never mind that, sister.

De Verby

Doubtless the young girl deserves some recompense, and I

suppose you

*will give her fifteen or twenty thousand francs,—that is due
her.*

Mme. du Brocard

*You see, sister, that M. de Verby is a noble and generous
man, and*

*since he has fixed upon this sum, I think it will be
sufficient.*

Justine

M. Rousseau!

Mme. du Brocard

O brother!

Mme. Rousseau

Dear husband!

SCENE FIFTH

The same persons and Rousseau.

De Verby (to Rousseau)

Have you good news?

Mme. Rousseau

Is he acquitted?

Rousseau

*No, but it is rumored that he is going to be; the jury are in
consultation; I couldn't stay there any longer; I couldn't
stand the*

*suspense; I told Antoine to hurry here as soon as the verdict
is
given.*

Mme. Rousseau

*We shall learn what the verdict is from this window; we have
agreed*

upon a signal to be given by that youth, Joseph Binet.

Rousseau

Ah! keep a good look out, Justine.

Mme. Rousseau

And how is Jules? What a trying time it must be for him!

Rousseau

Not at all! The unfortunate boy astonishes me by his coolness. Such

courage as he has is worthy of a better cause than that of conspiracy.

To think of his having put us in such a position! But for this I might

have been appointed President of the Chamber of Commerce.

De Verby

You forget that, after all, his marriage with a member of my family

will make some amends for his trouble.

Rousseau (struck by a sudden thought)

Ah, general! When I left the court room, Jules stood surrounded by his

friends, among whom were M. Dupre and the young girl Pamela. Your

niece and Madame de Verby must have noticed it, and I hope that you

will try to explain matters to them.

(While Rousseau speaks with the general the ladies are watching for

the signal.)

De Verby

Rest assured of that! I will take care that Jules appears as white as

snow! It is of very great importance to explain this affair of the

working-girl, otherwise the Comtesse de Verby might oppose the

marriage. We must explain away this apparent amour, and she must be

made to understand that the girl's evidence was a piece of self-

sacrifice for which she had been paid.

Rousseau

I certainly intend to do my duty towards that young girl. I shall give

her eight or ten thousand francs. It seems to me that that will be

liberal, very liberal!

Mme. Rousseau (while Mme. du Brocard tries to restrain her)

Ah, sir, but what of her honor?

Rousseau

Well, I suppose that some one will marry her.

SCENE SIXTH

The same persons and Joseph.

Joseph (dashing in)

Monsieur! Madame! Give me some cologne or something, I beg you!

All

Whatever can be the matter?

Joseph

M. Antoine, your footman, is bringing Pamela here.

Rousseau

Has anything happened?

Joseph

When she saw the jury come in to give their verdict she was taken ill!

Her father and mother, who were in the crowd at the other end of the

court, couldn't stir. I cried out, and the presiding judge made them

put me out of court!

Mme. Rousseau

But Jules! My son! What did the jury say?

Joseph

I know nothing! I had no eyes except for Pamela. As for your son, I suppose he is all right, but first with me comes Pamela—

De Verby
But you must have seen how the jury looked!

Joseph
Oh, yes! The foreman of the jury looked so gloomy—so severe—that I am quite persuaded— (He shudders.)

Mme. Rousseau
My poor Jules!

Joseph
Here comes Antoine and Mlle. Pamela.

SCENE SEVENTH

The same persons, Antoine and Pamela.

(They lead Pamela to a seat and give her smelling salts.)

Mme. du Brocard
My dear child!

Mme. Rousseau
My daughter!

Rousseau
Mademoiselle!

Pamela
I couldn't stand it any longer, the excitement was too great—and the suspense was so cruel. I tried to brace up my courage by the calmness of M. Jules while the jury was deliberating; the smile which he wore made me share his presentiment of coming release! But I was chilled to the heart when I looked at the pale, impassive countenance of

M.

Dupre!—And then, the sound of the bell that announced the return of

the jury, and the murmur of anxiety that ran through the court—I was

quite overcome!—A cold sweat suffused my cheek and I fainted.

Joseph

As for me, I shouted out, and they threw me into the street.

De Verby (to Rousseau)

If by mischance—

Rousseau

Sir!

De Verby (to Rousseau and the women)

If it should be necessary to appeal the case (pointing to Pamela),

could we count upon her?

Mme. Rousseau

On her? To the end; I am sure of that.

Mme. du Brocard

Pamela!

Rousseau

Tell me, you who have shown yourself so good, so generous,—if we

should still have need of your unselfish aid, would you be ready?

Pamela

Quite ready, sir! I have but one object, one single thought!—and that

is, to save M. Jules!

Joseph (aside)

She loves him, she loves him!

Rousseau

Ah! all that I have is at your disposal.

(A murmur and cries are heard; general alarm.)

All

What a noise they are making! Listen to their shouts!

(Pamela totters to her feet. Joseph runs to the window, where Justine is watching.)

Joseph

There's a crowd of people rushing down the steps of the court,—they are coming here!

Justine and Joseph

It is M. Jules!

Rousseau and Mme. Rousseau

My son!

Mme. du Brocard and Pamela

Jules!

(They rush forward to Jules.)

De Verby

He is acquitted!

SCENE EIGHTH

The same persons and Jules (brought in by his mother and his aunt and followed by his friends).

(Jules flings himself into the arms of his mother; he does not at

first see Pamela, who is seated in a corner near Joseph.)

Jules

O mother! Dear aunt! And my father! Here I am, restored to liberty

again! (To General de Verby and the friends who have come with him)

Let me thank you, general, and you, my friends, for your kind

sympathy.

(After general handshaking the friends depart.)

Mme. Rousseau

And so my son has at last come back to me! It seems too good
to be
true.

Joseph (to Pamela)

Well, and what of you? He hasn't said a word to you, and you
are the
only one he hasn't seen.

Pamela

Silence, Joseph, silence!

(Pamela retires to the end of the stage.)

De Verby

Not only have you been acquitted, but you have also gained a
high
place in the esteem of those who are interested in the
affair! You
have exhibited both courage and discretion, such as have
gratified us
all.

Rousseau

Everybody has behaved well. Antoine, you have done nobly; you
will end
your life in this house.

Mme. Rousseau (to Jules)

Let me express my gratitude to M. Adolph Durand.

(Jules presents his friend.)

Jules

Yes, but my real deliverer, my guardian angel is poor Pamela!
How well
she understood my situation and her own also! What self-
sacrifice she
showed! Can I ever forget her emotion, her terror!—and then
she

fainted! (Mme. Rousseau, who has been thinking of nothing else but her

son, now looks around for Pamela, sees her, and brings her up to

Jules.) Ah, Pamela! Pamela! My gratitude to you shall be eternal!

Pamela

Ah, M. Jules! How happy I feel.

Jules

We will never part again? Will we, mother? She shall be your daughter!

De Verby (to Rousseau with vehemence)

My sister and my niece are expecting an answer; you will have to

exercise your authority, sir. This young man seems to have a lively

and romantic imagination. He is in danger of missing his career

through a too scrupulous sense of honor, and a generosity which is

tinged with folly!

Rousseau (in embarrassment)

The fact is—

De Verby

But I have your word.

Mme. du Brocard

Speak out, brother!

Jules

Mother, do you answer them, and show yourself on my side?

Rousseau (taking Jules by the hand)

Jules! I shall never forget the service which this young girl has done

us. I understand the promptings of your gratitude; but as you are

aware the Comte de Verby has our promise; it is not right that you

should lightly sacrifice your future! You are not wanting in

energy,

you have given sufficient proof of that! A young conspirator should be quite able to extricate himself from such an affair as this.

De Verby (to Jules)

Undoubtedly! And our future diplomat will have a splendid chance.

Rousseau

Moreover my wishes in the matter—

Jules

O father!

Dupre (appearing)

Jules, I still have to take up your defence.

Pamela and Joseph

M. Dupre!

Jules

My friend!

Mme. du Brocard

It is the lawyer.

Dupre

I see! I am no longer "my dear Monsieur Dupre"!

Mme. du Brocard

Oh, you are always that! But before paying our debt of gratitude to

you, we have to think about this young girl.

Dupre (coldly)

I beg your pardon, madame.

De Verby

This man is going to spoil everything.

Dupre (to Rousseau)

I heard all you said. It transcends all I have ever experienced. I

could not have believed that ingratitude could follow so soon

on the

acceptance of a benefit. Rich as you are, rich as your son will be,

what fairer task have you to perform than that of satisfying your

conscience? In saving Jules, this girl has brought disgrace upon

herself! Can it be possible that the fortune which you have so

honorably gained should have killed in your heart every generous

sentiment, and that self-interest alone— (He sees Mme. du Brocard

making signs to her brother.) Ah! that is right, madame! It is you

that give the tone in this household! And I forgot while I was

pleading to this gentleman, that you would be at his elbow when I was

no longer here.

Mme. du Brocard

We have pledged our word to the Count and Countess of Verby! Mlle.

Pamela, whose friend I shall be all my life, did not effect the

deliverance of my nephew on the understanding that she should blight

his prospects.

Rousseau

There ought to be some basis of equality in a union by marriage. My

son will some day have an income of eighty thousand francs.

Joseph (aside)

That suits me to a T. I shall marry her now. But this fellow here, he

talks more like a Jewish money-changer than a father.

De Verby (to Dupre)

I think, sir, that your talent and character are such as to claim our

highest admiration and esteem. The Rousseau family will always

preserve your name in grateful memory; but these private discussions

must be carried on without witnesses from outside. M. Rousseau has

given me his word and I keep him to his promise! (To Jules)
Come, my

young friend, come to my brother's house; my niece is expecting you.

To-morrow we will sign the marriage contract.

(Pamela falls senseless on her chair.)

Joseph

Ah, what have you done! Mlle. Pamela!

Dupre and Jules (darting towards her)

Good heavens!

De Verby (taking Jules by the hand)

Come—come—

Dupre

Stop a moment! I should have been glad to think that I was not the

only protector that was left her! But listen, the matter is not yet

ended! Pamela will certainly be arrested as a false witness! (Seizes

the hand of De Verby.) And you will all be ruined.

(Dupre leads off Pamela.)

Joseph (hiding behind a sofa)

Don't tell anybody that I am here!

Curtain to the Fourth Act.

ACT V

SCENE FIRST

(The stage setting represents the private study in Dupre's house. On one side is a bookcase, on the other a desk. On the left is a window hung with heavy, sweeping silk curtains.)

Dupre, Pamela, Giraud and Madame Giraud.

(Pamela is seated on a chair reading; her mother is standing in front of her; Giraud is examining the pictures on the wall; Dupre is striding up and down the room.)

Dupre (stopping, addresses Giraud)
Did you take your usual precautions in coming here this morning?

Giraud
You may rest assured of that, sir; when I come here I walk with my head turned backwards! I know well enough that the least want of caution quickly results in misfortune. Your heart, my daughter, has led you astray this time; perjury is a terrible thing and I am afraid you are in a serious mess.

Mme. Giraud
I agree with you. You must be very careful, Giraud, for if any one were to follow you and discover that our poor daughter was here in

concealment, through the generosity of M. Dupre—

Dupre

Come now, enough of that! (He continues to stride hastily about the

room.) What ingratitude! The Rousseau family are ignorant of what

steps I have taken. They believe that Pamela has been arrested, and

none of them trouble their heads about it! They have sent Jules off to

Brussels; De Verby is in the country; and Rousseau carries on his

business at the Bourse as if nothing else was worth living for. Money,

ambition, are their sole objects. The higher feelings count for

nothing! They all worship the golden calf. Money makes them dance

round their idol; the sight of it blinds them.

(Pamela has been watching him, she rises and approaches him.)

Pamela

M. Dupre, you are agitated, you seem unwell. I fear it is on my

account.

Dupre

Have you not shared my disgust at the hateful want of feeling manifested by this family, who, as soon as their son is acquitted,

throw you aside as a mere tool that has served their purpose?

Pamela

But what can we do about it, sir?

Dupre

Dear child, does your heart feel no bitterness against them?

Pamela

No, sir! I am happier than any of them; for I feel that I have done a good deed.

Mme. Giraud (embracing Pamela)
My poor dear daughter!

Giraud
This is the happiest moment of my life.

Dupre (addressing Pamela)
Mademoiselle, you are a noble girl! No one has better ground for saying it than I, for it was I who came to you imploring you to speak the truth; and pure and honorable as you are, you have compromised your character for the sake of another. And now they repulse you and treat you with contempt; but I look upon you with hearty admiration—you shall yet be happy, for I will make full reparation to you! Pamela, I am forty-eight years old. I have some reputation, and a fortune. I have spent my life as an honest man, and will finish it as such; will you be my wife?

Pamela (much moved)
I, sir?

Giraud
His wife! Our daughter his wife! What do you say to that, Mme. Giraud?

Mme. Giraud
Can it be possible?

Dupre
Why should you wonder at this? Let us have no idle phrases. Put the question to your own heart—and answer yes or no—Will you be my wife?

Pamela
You are a great man, sir, and I owe everything to you. Do you really wish to add to the debt? Ah! my gratitude—!

Dupre

Don't let me hear you use that word,—it spoils everything!
The world
is something that I despise! And I render to it no account of
my
conduct, my hatred or my love. From the moment I saw your
courage and
your resignation—I loved you. Try to love me in return!

Pamela

Ah, sir, indeed I will!

Mme. Giraud

Could any one help loving you?

Giraud

Sir, I am only a poor porter. I repeat it, I am nothing but a
porter.

You love our daughter, you have told her so. Forgive me—my
eyes are

full of tears—and that checks my utterance. (He wipes his
eyes.)

Well, well, you do right to love her! It proves that you have
brains!

For Pamela—there are a great many landowners' children who
are her

inferiors. But it is humiliating for her to have parents such
as us.

Pamela

O father!

Giraud

You are a leader among men! Well, I and my wife, we will go
and hide

ourselves somewhere far into the country! And on Sunday, at
the hour

of mass, you will say, "They are praying to God for us!"

(Pamela kisses her parents.)

Dupre

You are good people, and to think that such as you have
neither title

nor fortune! And if you are pining for your country home, you shall

return there and live there in happiness and tranquillity, and I will

make provision for you.

Giraud and Mme. Giraud

Oh! our gratitude—

Dupre

That word again—I should like to cut it out of the dictionary!

Meanwhile I intend to take you both with me into the country, so set

about packing up.

Giraud

Sir!

Dupre

Well, what is it?

Giraud

Poor Joseph Binet is also in danger. He does not know that we are all

here. But three days ago, he came to see your servant and seemed

scared almost to death, and he is hidden here, as in a sanctuary, up

in the attic.

Dupre

Call him down-stairs.

Giraud

He will not come, sir; he is too much afraid of being arrested—they

pass him up food through a hole in the ceiling!

Dupre

He will soon be at liberty, I hope. I am expecting a letter which will

relieve all your minds.

Giraud

At once?

Dupre

I expect the letter this evening.

Giraud (to his wife)

I am going to make my way cautiously to the house.

(Madame Giraud accompanies him, and gives him advice. Pamela arises to follow her.)

Dupre (restraining Pamela)

You are not in love with this Binet, are you?

Pamela

Oh, never!

Dupre

And the other?

Pamela (struggling with her feelings)

I shall love none but you!

(Pamela starts to leave the room. A noise is heard in the antechamber.

Jules appears.)

SCENE SECOND

Pamela, Dupre and Jules.

Jules (to the servants)

Let me pass! I tell you—I must speak to him at once!
(Noticing Dupre)

Ah, sir! What has become of Pamela? Is she at liberty? Is she safe?

Pamela (stopping at the door)

Jules!

Jules

Good heavens! You here?

Dupre

And you, sir, I thought you were at Brussels?

Jules

Yes, they sent me away against my will, and I yielded to them! Reared

as I have been in obedience, I still tremble before my family! But I

carried away with me the memory of what I had left behind! It has

taken me six months to realize the situation, and I now acknowledge

that I risked my life in order to obtain the hand of Mlle. de Verby,

that I might gratify the ambition of my family, or, if you like, might

honor my own vanity. I hoped some day to be a man of title, I, the son

of a rich stock-broker! Then I met Pamela, and I fell in love with

her! The rest you know! What was a mere sentiment has now become a

duty, and every hour that has kept me from her I have felt that

obedience to my family was rank cowardice; and while they believe I am

far away, I have returned! You told me she had been arrested—and to

think that I should run away (to both of them) without coming to see

you, who had been my deliverer, and will be hers also.

Dupre (looking at them)

Good! Very good! He is an honorable fellow after all.

Pamela (aside, drying her tears)

Thank God for that!

Dupre

What do you expect to do? What are your plans?

Jules

What are my plans? To unite my fortune with hers. If necessary, to

forfeit everything for her, and under God's protection to say to her,

"Pamela, will you be mine?"

Dupre

The deuce you say! But there is a slight difficulty in the way—for I am going to marry her myself.

Jules (in great astonishment)

You?

Dupre

Yes, I! (Pamela casts down her eyes.) I have no family to oppose my wishes.

Jules

I will win over mine.

Dupre

They will send you off to Brussels again.

Jules

I must run and find my mother; my courage has returned! Were I to

forfeit the favor of my father, were my aunt to cut me off with a sou,

I would stand my ground. If I did otherwise, I should be destitute of

self-respect, I should prove myself a soulless coward.—After that, is

there any hope for me?

Dupre

Do you ask such a question of me?

Jules

Pamela, answer, I implore you!

Pamela (to Dupre)

I have given you my word, sir.

SCENE THIRD

The same persons and a servant.

(The servant hands a card to Dupre.)

Dupre (looking at the card with great surprise)
How is this? (To Jules) Do you know where M. de Verby is?

Jules
He is in Normandy, staying with his brother, Comte de Verby.

Dupre (looking at the card)
Very good. Now you had better go and find your mother.

Jules
But you promise me?

Dupre
I promise nothing.

Jules
Good-bye, Pamela! (Aside, as he goes out) I will come back soon.

Dupre (turning towards Pamela, after the departure of Jules)
Must he come back again?

Pamela (with great emotion, throwing herself into his arms)
Ah! sir! (Exit.)

Dupre (looking after her and wiping away a tear)
Gratitude, forsooth! (Opening a narrow secret door.) Come in, general;
come in!

SCENE FOURTH

Dupre and De Verby.

Dupre
Strange, sir, to find you here, when every one believes that you are

fifty leagues away from Paris.

De Verby

I arrived this morning.

Dupre

Without doubt some powerful motive brought you here?

De Verby

No selfish motive; but I couldn't remain wholly indifferent to the affairs of others! You may prove useful to me.

Dupre

I shall be only too happy to have an opportunity of serving you.

Du Verby

M. Dupre, the circumstances under which we have become acquainted have put me in a position fully to appreciate your value. You occupy the first place among the men whose talents and character claim my attention.

Dupre

Ah! sir, you compel me to say that you, a veteran of the Empire, have always seemed to me by your loyalty and your independence to be a fitting representative of that glorious epoch. (Aside) I hope I have paid him back in full.

De Verby

I suppose I may rely upon you for assistance?

Dupre

Certainly.

De Verby

I would like to ask for some information with regard to young Pamela Giraud.

Dupre

I felt sure that was your object.

De Verby

The Rousseau family have behaved abominably.

Dupre

Would you have behaved any better?

De Verby

I intend to espouse her cause! Since her arrest as a perjurer, how do things go on?

Dupre

That can have very little interest for you.

De Verby

That may be true, but—

Dupre (aside)

He is trying to make me talk in order to find out whether he is likely

to be compromised in the case. (Aloud) General de Verby, there are

some men who cannot be seen through, either in their plans or in their

thoughts; the actions and events which they give rise to alone reveal

and explain such men. These are the strong men. I humbly beg that you

will pardon my frankness when I say that I don't look upon you as

being one of them.

De Verby

Sir! What language to use to me! You are a singular man!

Dupre

More than that! I believe that I am an original man! Listen to me. You

throw out hints to me, and you think that as a future ambassador you

can try on me your diplomatic methods; but you have chosen

the wrong

man and I am going to tell you something, which you will take no

pleasure in learning. You are ambitious, but you are also prudent, and

you have taken the lead in a certain conspiracy. The plot failed, and

without worrying yourself about those whom you had pushed to the

front, and who eagerly strove for success, you have yourself sneaked

out of the way. As a political renegade you have proved your independence by burning incense to the new dynasty! And you expect as

a reward to be made ambassador to Turin! In a month's time you will

receive your credentials; meanwhile Pamela is arrested, you have been

seen at her house, you may possibly be compromised by her trial for

perjury! Then you rush to me, trembling with the fear of being

unmasked, of losing the promotion which has caused you so many efforts

to attain! You come to me with an air of obsequiousness, and with the

words of flattery, expecting to make me your dupe, and thus to show

your sincerity! Well, you have sufficient reason for alarm—Pamela is

in the hands of justice, and she has told all.

De Verby

What then is to be done?

Dupre

I have one suggestion to make: Write to Jules that you release him

from his engagement, and the Mlle. de Verby withdraws her promise to

be his wife.

De Verby

Is that your advice?

Dupre

You find that the Rousseau family have behaved abominably,
and you
ought to despise them!

De Verby

But you know—engagements of this sort—

Dupre

I'll tell you what I know; I know that your private fortune
is not
equal to the position which you aspire to. Mme. du Brocard,
whose
wealth is equal to her pride, ought to come to your
assistance, if
this alliance—

De Verby

Sir! How dare you to affront my dignity in this way?

Dupre

Whether what I say be true or false, do what I tell you! If
you agree,
I will endeavor to save you from being compromised. But write
—or get
out of the difficulty the best way you can. But stay, I hear
some
clients coming.

De Verby

I don't want to see anybody! Everybody, even the Rousseau
family,
believes that I have left the city.

A servant (announcing a visitor)

Madame du Brocard!

De Verby

Oh, heavens!

(De Verby rushes into an office on the right.)

SCENE FIFTH

Dupre and Madame du Brocard.

(Madame du Brocard enters, her face hidden by a heavy black veil which she cautiously raises.)

Mme. du Brocard

I have been here several times without being lucky enough to find you in. We are quite alone here?

Dupre (smiling)
Quite alone!

Mme. du Brocard

And so this harrowing affair has broken out afresh?

Dupre

It has, unhappily!

Mme. du Brocard

That wretched young man! If I had not superintended his education, I

would disinherit him! My life at present is not worth living. Is it

possible that I, whose conduct and principles have won the esteem of

all, should be involved in all this trouble? And yet on this occasion

the only thing that gives me any anxiety is my conduct towards the

Girauds!

Dupre

I can well believe it, for it was you who led astray and who induced

Pamela to act as she did!

Mme. du Brocard

I feel, sir, that it is always a mistake to associate with people of a

certain class—say, with a Bonapartist—a man who has neither conscience nor heart.

(De Verby, who has been listening, shrinks back with a gesture of rage.)

Dupre

You always seemed to have such a high opinion of him!

Mme. du Brocard

His family was highly thought of! And the prospect of this brilliant marriage! I always dreamt of a distinguished future for my nephew.

Dupre

But you are forgetting the general's affection for you, his unselfishness.

Mme. du Brocard

His affection! His unselfishness! The general does not possess a sou, and I had promised him a hundred thousand francs, when once the marriage contract was signed.

Dupre (coughs loudly, as he turns in the direction of De Verby)

Oh! indeed!

Mme. du Brocard

I am come to you secretly, and in confidence, in spite of all that has been said by this M. de Verby, who avers that you are a half-rate lawyer! He has said the most frightful things about you, and I come now to beg that you will extricate me from this difficulty. I will give you whatever money you demand.

Dupre

What I wish above all is that you promise to let your nephew marry whom he chooses, and give him the fortune you had designed for him, in

case he married Mlle. de Verby.

Mme. du Brocard

One moment; you said, whom he pleased?

Dupre

Give me your answer!

Mme. du Brocard

But I ought to know.

Dupre

Very well then, you must extricate yourself without my assistance.

Mme. du Brocard

You are taking advantage of my situation! Ah! some one is coming.

Dupre (looking towards the newcomers)

It is some of your own family!

Mme. du Brocard (peering cautiously)

It is my brother-in-law Rousseau—What is he up to now? He swore to me that he would keep quiet!

Dupre

You also took an oath. In fact, there has been a great deal of swearing in your family lately.

Mme. du Brocard

I hope I shall be able to hear what he has to say!

(Rousseau appears with his wife. Mme. du Brocard conceals herself behind the curtain.)

Dupre (looking at her)

Very good! But if these two want to hide themselves, I don't know where I shall put them!

SCENE SIXTH

Dupre, Rousseau and Madame Rousseau.

Rousseau

*Sir, we are at our wits' end—Madame du Brocard, my sister-in-law,
came this morning and told us all sorts of stories.*

Mme. Rousseau

Sir, I am in the most serious alarm.

Dupre (offering her a seat)

Pray be seated, madame.

Rousseau

If all she says be true, my son is still in difficulties.

Dupre

I pity you; I do indeed!

Rousseau

It seems as if I should never get free! This unfortunate affair has

lasted for six months, and it seems to have cut ten years off my life.

I have been forced to neglect the most magnificent speculations,

financial combinations of absolute certitude, and to let them pass

into the hands of others. And then came the trial! But when I thought

the affair was all over, I have been compelled once more to leave my

business, and to spend my precious time in these interviews and

solicitations.

Dupre

I pity you; I do indeed!

Mme. Rousseau

Meanwhile it is impossible for me—

Rousseau

It is all your fault, and that of your family. Mme. du Brocard, who at first used always to call me "my dear Rousseau"—because I had a few hundred thousand crowns—

Dupre

Such a sum is a fine varnish for a man.

Rousseau

From pride and ambition, she threw herself at the head of M. de Verby.

(De Verby and Mme. du Brocard listen.) Pretty couple they are! Two

charming characters, one a military lobbyist, and the other an old hypocritical devotee!

(The two withdraw their heads quickly.)

Mme. Rousseau

Sir, she is my sister!

Dupre

Really, you are going too far!

Rousseau

You do not know them! Sir, I address you once again, there is sure to

be a new trial. What has become of that girl?

Dupre

That girl is to be my wife, sir.

Rousseau and Mme. Rousseau

Your wife!

De Verby and Mme. du Brocard

His wife!

Dupre

Yes, I shall marry her as soon as she regains her liberty—that is,

provided she doesn't become the wife of your son!

Rousseau

The wife of my son!—

Mme. Rousseau

What did he say?

Dupre

What is the matter? Does that astonish you? You're bound to entertain

this proposal—and I demand that you do so.

Rousseau (ironically)

Ah! M. Dupre, I don't care a brass button about my son's union with

Mlle. de Verby—the niece of a disreputable man! It was that fool of a

Madame du Brocard who tried to bring about this grand match. But to

come down to a daughter of a porter—

Dupre

Her father is no longer that, sir!

Rousseau

What do you mean?

Dupre

He lost his place through your son, and he intends returning to the

country, to live on the money— (Rousseau listens attentively) on the

money which you have promised to give him.

Rousseau

Ah! you are joking!

Dupre

On the contrary, I am quite serious. Your son will marry their

daughter—and you will provide a pension for the old people.

Rousseau

Sir—

SCENE SEVENTH

The same persons and Joseph (coming in pale and faint).

Joseph

M. Dupre, M. Dupre, save me!

All three

What has happened? What is the matter?

Joseph

Soldiers! Mounted soldiers are coming to arrest me!

Dupre

Hold your tongue! Hold your tongue! (Everybody seems alarmed.

Dupre

looks with anxiety towards the room where Pamela is. To Joseph) To arrest you?

Joseph

I saw one of them. Don't you hear him? He is coming upstairs. Hide me!

(Joseph tries to hide himself in the small room, from which De Verby comes out with a cry.)

De Verby

Ah!

(Joseph gets behind the curtain and Mme. du Brocard rushes forth with a shriek.)

Mme. du Brocard

Oh, heavens!

Mme. Rousseau

My sister!

Rousseau

M. de Verby!

(The door opens.)

Joseph (falling exhausted over a chair)
We are all nabbed.

The servant (entering, to Dupre)
A message from the Keeper of the Seals.

Joseph
The Keeper of the Seals! That must be about me!

Dupre (advancing with a serious face and addressing the four others)

I shall now leave you all four face to face—you whose mutual love and esteem is so great. Ponder well all I have said to you; she who

sacrificed all for you, has been despised and humiliated, both for you

and by you. It is yours to make full reparation to her—to make it

to-day—this very instant—in this very room. And then, we can take

measures by which all can obtain deliverance, if indeed you are worth

the trouble it will cost me.

(Exit Dupre.)

SCENE EIGHTH

The same persons with the exception of Dupre.

(They stand looking awkwardly at each other for a moment.)

Joseph (going up to them)

We are a nice lot of people. (To De Verby) I should like to know when

we are put in prison, whether you are going to look out for me, for my

pocket is as light as my heart is heavy. (De Verby turns his

back on

him. To Rousseau) You know well enough that I was promised something

for my services. (Rousseau withdraws from him without answering. To

Mme. du Brocard) Tell me now, wasn't something promised to me?

Mme. du Brocard

We will see about that later.

Mme. Rousseau

But what do you fear? What are you doing in this place? Were you

pursued by any one?

Joseph

Not at all. I have been four days in this house, hidden like so much

vermin in the garret. I came here because the old Giraud people were

not to be found in their quarters. They have been carried off somewhere. Pamela has also disappeared—she is doubtless in hiding. I

had no particular desire to run any risk; I admit that I lied to the

judge. If I am condemned I will obtain my freedom by making a few

startling revelations; I will tell on everybody!—

De Verby (with energy)

It must be done!

(De Verby sits at the table and writes.)

Mme. du Brocard

O Jules, Jules! Wretched child, you are the cause of all this!

Mme. Rousseau (to her husband)

You see, this lawyer has got you all in his power! You will have to

agree to his terms.

(De Verby rises from the table. Mme. du Brocard takes his

*place and
begins to write.)*

*Mme. Rousseau (to her husband)
My dear, I implore you!*

*Rousseau (with decision)
By heavens! I shall promise to this devil of a lawyer all
that he asks
of me; but Jules is at Brussels.*

*(The door opens, Joseph cries out in alarm, but it is Dupre
who
enters.)*

SCENE NINTH

The same persons and Dupre.

*Dupre
How is this?*

*(Mme du Brocard hands him the letter she has been writing; De
Verby
hands him his; and it is passed over to Rousseau who reads it
with
astonishment; De Verby casts a furious glance at Dupre and
the
Rousseau family, and dashes out of the room.)*

*Dupre (to Rousseau)
And what decision have you made, sir?*

*Rousseau
I shall let my son do exactly what he wants in the matter.*

*Mme. Rousseau
Dear husband!*

*Dupre (aside)
He thinks that Jules is out of town.*

Rousseau

At present Jules is at Brussels, and he must return at once.

Dupre

That is perfectly fair! It is quite clear that I can't demand anything

at the moment of you, so long as he is away; to do so would be absurd.

Rousseau

Certainly! We can settle matters later.

Dupre

Yes, as soon as he returns.

Rousseau

Oh! as soon as he returns. (Aside) I will take pretty good care that

he remains where he is.

Dupre (going towards the door on the left)

Come in, young man, and thank your family, who have given their full

consent to your marriage.

Mme. Rousseau

It is Jules!

Mme. du Brocard

It is my nephew!

Jules

Can it be possible?

Dupre (darting towards another room)

And you, Pamela, my child, my daughter!—embrace your husband.

(Jules rushes towards her.)

Mme. du Brocard (to Rousseau)

How has all this come about?

Dupre

Pamela never was arrested. There is no likelihood of her ever being. I

haven't a title of nobility. I am not the brother of a peer

of France,

but still I have some influence. The self-sacrifice of this poor girl

has aroused the sympathy of the government—the indictment has been

quashed. The Keeper of the Seals has sent me word of this by an

orderly on horseback, whom this simpleton took for a regiment of

soldiers in pursuit of him.

Joseph

It is very hard to see plainly through a garret window.

Mme. du Brocard

Sir, you have caught me by surprise; I take back my promise.

Dupre

But I still have possession of your latter. Do you wish to have a

lawsuit about it? Very well, I will appear against you on the other side.

Giraud and Mme. Giraud (entering and approaching Dupre)

M. Dupre!

Dupre

Are you satisfied with me?

(In the meantime Jules and Mme. Rousseau have been imploring Rousseau

to yield his consent; he hesitates, but at last kisses Pamela on the

forehead. Dupre approaches Rousseau and, seeing him kiss Pamela,

wrings his hand.)

Dupre

You have done well, sir. (Then turning to Jules) Will you make her happy?

Jules

Ah, my friend, you need not ask!

(Pamela kisses the hand of Dupre.)

Joseph (to Dupre)

What a fool I have been! Well, he is going to marry her, and I am actually glad for them! But am I not to get something out of all this?

Dupre

Certainly, you shall have all the fees that come to me from the lawsuit.

Joseph

You may count on my gratitude.

Dupre

That will be receipt in full!

Final curtain.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK PAMELA
GIRAUD: A PLAY IN FIVE ACTS ***

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